

Ronnie Taylor

Senior Software Engineer • Full-Stack

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Summary

Full-stack software engineer with nearly two decades of experience building and maintaining production systems across backend services, payment platforms, cloud infrastructure, and developer tooling. Comfortable leading teams or working as an individual contributor. Currently deepening hands-on Python and React skills, and have spent the past year building local AI tooling — running AI models on private infrastructure, building tool integrations, and setting up systems that let AI work against an organization's own data without sending that data to outside services.

Skills

Languages: Python, Ruby, JavaScript / TypeScript, SQL, PHP

Frameworks & Libraries: React, Ruby on Rails, Ractive, Sinatra, Node.js

Cloud & Infrastructure: AWS (EC2, ECS, S3, RDS, ElastiCache, CloudWatch), Docker, Vault, Consul

AI Tooling: Building and running AI models on private infrastructure (Open WebUI), setting up retrieval systems over internal documents, integrating AI coding tools (GitHub Copilot, Opencode, Hermes)

DevOps & Tooling: CI/CD (GitHub Actions, CircleCI), Git, Datadog, ScoutAPM, PostgreSQL, Microsoft SQL Server

Practices: Test-driven development, OAuth2, payment systems, security auditing and remediation, mentorship

Experience

Engineering Sabbatical — AI Tooling & Open Source

July 2025 – Present

After a layoff, took a deliberate break to focus on learning and building — specifically around running AI models on private infrastructure, an area I think matters a lot for organizations that handle sensitive data.

- Built Python-based tool servers that let a locally-running AI model call out to external services and APIs — keeping the AI and the data it works with entirely on private infrastructure rather than sending anything to outside cloud providers.
- Set up and tuned systems that let an AI model search and reason over an organization's own internal documents, rather than relying solely on its training data. This kind of setup is especially useful for organizations — like healthcare companies — that can't send their records to third-party AI services.
- Studied and contributed to open-source projects (Opencode, Hermes, and others) that use AI to plan and carry out multi-step programming tasks — all Python-based, which deepened my practical fluency with the language.
- Extended existing Python scripting work: hardware interfacing on Raspberry Pi (temperature/humidity sensors, LCD displays) and enterprise utility scripts for downloading and decrypting infrastructure backups.

Senior Staff Engineer — Platform Team Tech Lead

March 2024 – June 2025

Veracross • Remote, United States

Led platform engineering for a globally distributed team spanning Australia, South America, the United States, and Europe.

- Led the migration of our CI/CD pipeline from CircleCI to GitHub Actions, cutting build times by 45%.
- Worked with external security vendors to audit the application for vulnerabilities, then led the remediation effort across the engineering team.
- Introduced AI coding tools — GitHub Copilot and locally-hosted language models — that measurably sped up development and reduced repetitive work.
- Mentored engineers across time zones and organized company-wide technical talks to spread knowledge across teams.

Staff Product Engineer

March 2020 – March 2024

Veracross • Remote, United States

- Extended our authentication system to support multiple third-party login providers via OAuth2.
- Built a fine-grained permission system for controlling employee access to internal tools, cutting onboarding and offboarding time by 50%.
- Added multi-language support to our core applications so the company could serve international customers without maintaining separate codebases.
- Worked with the DevOps team to modernize our AWS infrastructure, improving reliability and reducing downtime costs.
- Standardized Docker images for our SQL Server databases so developers could spin up a working local environment in minutes instead of hours.
- Mentored junior engineers through code reviews, pairing sessions, and regular 1:1s.

Web Services Manager

March 2018 – January 2020

Veracross • Remote, United States

- Led a team responsible for APIs, payment processing, and internal services — maintaining 99.99% uptime throughout.
- Introduced test-driven development across the team and raised automated test coverage from near zero to roughly 85%, dramatically reducing bugs making it to production.
- Built the organization's first CI/CD pipeline on CircleCI, cutting deployment time by 70% and making releases far less stressful.

Senior Software Engineer

April 2016 – March 2018

Veracross • Remote, United States

- Helped extend and maintain a tuition and fees payment platform that processes over \$1 billion annually, improving system availability to 99.998%.
- Set up monitoring and alerting with the DevOps team that reduced downtime incidents by 40% and made it much faster to diagnose problems when they did occur.
- Tightened security controls across the payment system to protect customer data and meet compliance requirements.

Lead Software Developer

May 2012 – March 2016

AppZero • Remote, United States & Canada

Led development of a web service that powered AppZero's tool for moving Windows applications between data centers — built in Ruby, Sinatra, Rails, PostgreSQL, and AWS.

- Worked directly with executive leadership, sales, and product to turn business goals into technical requirements.
- Designed the core architecture of the Zapp platform with scalability, reliability, and security as primary constraints.
- Delivered a migration tool that sped up customer onboarding, reduced downtime during migrations, and consistently received strong customer feedback.

Independent Web Developer & Consultant

January 2007 – May 2012

Ronnie Taylor Consulting • Remote, United States & Canada

Ran a web development consultancy building custom sites for clients across the US and Canada using HTML, CSS, JavaScript, PHP, MySQL, and PostgreSQL — handling everything from initial design through deployment and ongoing support.

- Built an e-commerce platform for a retail client that grew their online sales by 20% in the first quarter after launch.
- Implemented SEO improvements and CMS solutions (Drupal, WordPress, CodeIgniter) that gave clients control over their own content and improved search visibility.

Interactive Media Manager

April 2007 – April 2008

The Herald (McClatchy Newspapers) • Rock Hill, SC

Managed the IT and Interactive Media departments, covering project management, product development, web programming, annual budgeting, and coordination between local and corporate offices.

Education

Winthrop University

Business Administration and Management